

Hot war unlikely as Russia escalates hybrid activity

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Hot war with the West remains unlikely as Russia escalates hybrid activity

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The coming months will see an escalation of Russian hybrid warfare activity against NATO countries, who will adopt a mainly defensive posture against these measures, strengthening their resilience and refraining from responding with hybrid counterstrikes.

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Russia's hybrid escalation is unlikely to trigger all-out war between Russia and the West (10% probability), but cannot be completely excluded, given the potential for misjudgments and accidents to spiral into retaliation and escalation.

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The US has adopted a more reassuring posture in Europe in recent months, strengthening European security through increased diplomacy, military exercises, and ramped-up support for Ukraine, but the durability of that alignment remains a key signpost.

Russia will further escalate its conflict with NATO across the hybrid warfare spectrum. Moscow will likely use the full array of instruments, including cyber-attacks, sabotage, disinformation campaigns, arson, and assassinations. The recent uptick in such incidents in Germany, Poland, Bulgaria, Romania, the Czech Republic, the Baltic states, and other countries are the prelude to a protracted and increasingly intense altercation. Targets will range from IT networks and critical infrastructure to military and industrial sites (especially in the armaments sector), from targeted individuals to the broader public on the information front.

European NATO allies will focus on defensive measures rather than counterstrikes in the cyber sphere (70% probability). Those measures would include anti-drone systems, the hardening of IT systems, and increased homeland security. In a less likely scenario (20%), NATO allies would choose to strike back in the cyber sphere in a tit-for-tat manner, seeking to impose costs on Russia for its transgressions and re-establish NATO deterrence. Most European NATO allies are currently not in a position to conduct such operations, while Germany is in the process of creating legal conditions for its intelligence services to do so.

Intensified hybrid attacks increase the risk of spillover into kinetic attacks and more traditional forms of warfare. Spillover could occur accidentally or be triggered by miscalculations and misunderstandings, which, in turn, could lead to a kinetic military response, such as the shooting down of a jet or live fire against human targets.

A traditional kinetic military attack with regular forces on NATO territory is unlikely in the short- to medium-term (10% probability), but cannot be ruled out entirely. Such an attack could come as a quick, small-scale surprise, aimed at occupying and rapidly fortifying a small patch of territory that would then be difficult for NATO forces to retake quickly. The goal of such an operation would not be to conquer land, but to divide NATO allies over the response to a minor transgression. Another aim could be to use the occupied batch as a chip in negotiations, e.g., on European support for Ukraine. Military operations could come closely embedded in a hybrid operation, possibly triggered by a feigned humanitarian intervention on behalf of Russians abroad or a similarly staged occasion. Russia's lack of spare combat power while the war in Ukraine remains unresolved, and the risk of an Article 5 response that Moscow cannot control, are the core reasons this scenario remains low-probability. An Article 5 invocation would nonetheless force a decision within the alliance over how to respond to a limited territorial transgression—divisions Moscow would seek to exploit.

The US's incremental move toward alignment with Europe presents a more unified front to Russian escalation. The US's position on Russia and Ukraine is now more aligned with Europe and Kyiv than it was at the beginning of President Donald Trump's second term, despite the contradictory messaging around US special envoys Steven Witkoff and Jared Kushner's recent visit to Russia. US support for Ukrainian long-range strikes on Russian energy and logistics targets, elevation of CIA Director John Ratcliffe in engagement with Russia, and recent US involvement in major NATO exercises near the Russian exclave of Kaliningrad are all key signposts of more stable US backing against Russian escalation.

Potential redistribution of US forces in Europe, while understandably concerning to European leaders, will not reduce US presence below the 76,000-troop level codified by Congress, and the US presence will remain significantly above its pre-war level. Participation in European training exercises, such as the exercise near Kaliningrad, will serve as the clearest indicator of Washington's willingness to expand deterrence against Russia.

Europe will continue its military ramp-up and support for Ukraine, but options beyond that are limited. Additional support for Ukraine will include the 22nd EU sanctions package against Russia, designed to clamp down, among other measures, on Russia's "shadow fleet" of vessels enabling illicit Russian energy exports. The Europeans are unlikely to revisit the divisive issue of Russian frozen assets in the near future. Other measures could include stricter enforcement of trade sanctions, especially on dual-use technology, to dry up illicit Russian revenue streams.

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